



THOUSANDS OF YEARS AGO, THE BRITISH ISLES were invaded CELTIC PEOPLE CHILDREN OF ANCIENT INVADERS

Irish castles

Irish nobles from the 12th century onward protected themselves from invasion by living in castles with deep moats, thick walls, and fortified battlements. These were so well-built that many are still in good condition today and have been converted into hotels.



IRISH DANCING

Today, Irish dancing is extremely popular among people of Irish origin living outside of Ireland. Its popularity is partly due to the *Conradh na Gaeilge* (Gaelic League), which was founded in 1839 to revive Irish folk culture. The organization standardized Irish dances and still issues rules governing how they are taught and judged in competitions.



SCOTTISH TARTAN



The distinctive mark of a tartan check is the square formed where threads of two different colors cross. Although tartan cloth had existed in Scotland for hundreds of years, its popularity grew enormously at the end of the 18th century when clans began to identify strongly their own particular pattern.

THE HIGHLAND GAMES

With Scottish clans separated by miles of craggy hillsides, the Highland Games were a way for people to get together. Today, Highland Games are held in Scotland and elsewhere. Traditional competitions, such as caber tossing and throwing the hammer, lie at the heart of these events, but Scottish dancers, bagpipers, and drummers may feature too.

Throwing the hammer.

